

—to enroll her in Pioneer Middle, a local public school. For my sister to qualify to attend that school, we had to live in that district. They wanted her to go to Pioneer so she could transition into the A-rated public school, Cooper City High (again avoiding private school tuition). The public high school near our old house in Hollywood had a reputation for stabbings, so they wanted her in a free, and better, environment. (It's slim pickings anyway: Florida ranks twenty-ninth in the United States in quality of high school education.) The house we moved to in Cooper was smaller and cost \$275,000.

The sale of the house should have been a coup for us Dunns. But even more immediate than our family's money troubles were my dad's excessive drinking and drugging. He couldn't keep jobs. He was gambling. It all went hand in hand. (He's not shy about his past. He'll be the first to tell you stories of his pre-sobriety days if you ask him. Actually, don't ask him. You'll never shut him up.)

On a recent Thanksgiving trip home, I rediscovered my early-teen-years diary and was surprised to see that I wrote about money *a lot*. In September 2002, I wrote that I had complained about my eyesight and my dad told me he didn't want to "waste money" on an eye doctor visit. (I'm not sure if we had health insurance at the time.) I recounted how he and I went to the local pharmacy and picked up cheap eyeglasses that weren't my prescription. When those didn't work, he gave me my little sister's old eyeglasses, again not my prescription. In my entry about this, I despaired about the glasses being ugly, too small for my face, and not the right lenses. I decided not to wear glasses at all. (I currently wear glasses, so I guess there really was something wrong with my eyes.)

I also mentioned a few times in the diary how worried I was about my mom's spending at expensive stores like Bebe and Gucci, most often on gifts for my little sister, who to this day continues to enjoy the finer things.

In January 2003, I wrote in my journal, "On the way home, my mom asked why I had yelled at my sister in Abercrombie. I told her that either she should stop complaining about how broke we are or stop buying my sister clothes she doesn't need." Once home, I chronicled how my mom and dad got into a fight